



9 Kinds of Phrases

When some words work together as a unit but do not contain a *finite verb*, they are known as a *phrase*. In other words, a phrase is a group of words that does not contain a subject and a predicate.

Remember that we shall refer to a finite verb simply as *verb*.

We shall now look at three different kinds of phrases:

- (i) adjective phrases (ii) adverb phrases (iii) noun phrases



Adjective Phrases

A phrase which does the work of an *adjective* is an **adjective phrase**.

- (a) The books on the shelves are for sale.
(b) We saw a bird with beautiful feathers.

In (a), the group of words *on the shelves* does not contain any verb.

Secondly, the group as a whole describes the noun *books*.

(Q: Which *books*? Ans: books *on the shelves*)

So, this group of words is a phrase and does the work of an adjective. It is, therefore, an **adjective phrase**.

Note, however, that the phrase is made up of: *on* (preposition) + *the* (definite article) + *shelves* (noun).

Similarly, in (b), *with beautiful feathers* is a phrase and it describes the noun *bird*. So, it is an adjective phrase. It is made up of: *with* (preposition) + *beautiful* (adjective) + *feathers* (noun).

So, we can say that it does not matter what kind of words the phrase is made up of. What matters is the *work* it does as a whole—as a unit—in a clause or a sentence. As you have already seen that the *-ing* form of a verb may act as an adjective and can be used in a phrase.

(c) *Have you seen a flying fish?*

(d) *The eagle, flying high up in the sky, looked down at the cattle grazing below.*

In (c), *flying* has been used on its own as an adjective to qualify the noun *fish*.

(Q: What kind of *fish*? Ans: *flying*)

However, in (d), *flying* has been used with five other words—*high up in the sky*—to qualify a noun *eagle*. So, the six words—*flying high up in the sky*—act together as a unit, that is, as a phrase, to qualify the noun *eagle*.

[*flying* (-ing form of *fly*) + *high* (adverb of degree) + *up* (adverb of place) + *in* (preposition) + *the* (article) + *sky* (noun)]

Similarly, *grazing below* is an adjective phrase that qualifies the noun *cattle*.

[*grazing* (-ing form of *graze*) + *below* (adverb of place)]

Warning: When you come across the *-ing* form of a verb, you must try to find out whether it is acting as an adjective, or as a main verb with the aid of a helping verb. Remember that the *-ing* form cannot act as a main verb without another verb to help it.

(e) *The girl was picking flowers.*

(f) *The girl, picking flowers, is my sister.*

In (e), *picking* has been used with the helping verb *was* to form the past continuous tense of the verb *pick*.

In (f), *picking* has been used on its own, that is, there is no helping verb. So, it is not a verb—it has been used as an adjective to qualify the noun, *girl*.



A Pick out the **adjective phrases** from the following sentences:

1. The books, displayed in the glass case, are very valuable.
2. The bird, singing so sweetly, is a nightingale.
3. The circus, camping in the middle of the town, will soon go away.
4. We saw a crocodile lying in the sun.
5. The king's palace, built of marble, stood on the top of a hill.

6. The horses, wild and free, roamed all over the land.
7. The bus, carrying passengers from one village to another, will stop here.
8. The men, tired after the day's work, were sitting round the fire and chatting.
9. The cold wind, blowing from the north, made everybody shiver.
10. The city, devastated by the fire, has to be rebuilt as soon as possible.
11. The explorer showed us a strange box, carved of ivory and set with precious stones.
12. The marketplace was full of people, dressed in richly coloured clothes.
13. These books, dealing with mathematical problems, belong to Raj.
14. The painting, hanging on the wall, is by a famous artist.
15. Boys, studying in different schools, will join the adventure camp.



Adverb Phrases

A phrase which does the work of an adverb is an **adverb phrase**.

- (g) *Tarun followed the doctor's advice with utmost care.*
(h) *The play will begin in about an hour.*
(i) *You can get this book in all the bookshops.*
(j) *Jim will succeed because of his perseverance.*
(k) *If possible, let me have two tickets please.*

In (g), *with utmost care*, which does not contain a subject and a verb, tells us *how* Tarun followed the doctor's advice. So, *with utmost care* is an adverb phrase (*manner*).

In (h), *in about an hour*, which also does not have a subject and a verb, tells us *when* the play will begin. So, *in about an hour* is an adverb phrase (*time*).

In (i), *in all the bookshops* does not contain a subject and a verb. It tells us *where* the book is available and so it is an adverb phrase (*place*).

In (j), *because of his perseverance* does not contain a subject and a predicate. It gives the reason why Jim will succeed. So, it is an adverb phrase (*reason*).

In (k), *if possible* is an adverb phrase (*condition*)—whether something can be done *depends* (that is, *conditional*) on something else, that is, whether tickets can be given depends on whether tickets are available.

B Pick out the *adverb phrases* from the following sentences:

1. The doctor examined the patient with great care.
2. The patient was waiting in a room of the hospital.
3. We were building sandcastles on the wind-swept beach.
4. If you do something in a hurry, you will always make a mistake.
5. The boy ran as fast as the wind, but could not catch the thief.
6. Though he shouted at the top of his voice, nobody could hear him because of the loud music.
7. A large crowd had gathered in the hall in order to listen to the speaker.
8. The villagers expected the flood waters to recede in a month's time.
9. 'Please do not leave paper plates and glasses scattered all over the place after the picnic. Pick everything up and put them in the dustbin,' said mother.
10. The rowers rowed their hearts out, but could not overtake the other boat.
11. It was raining in the morning.
12. Guards were posted all round the building to protect the minister.
13. We shall come on Thursday, if possible.
14. Do not put all your eggs in the same basket.
15. The patient was advised to have a check-up twice a month.



Noun Phrases

A phrase which does the work of a noun is a **noun phrase**.

Remember that only a noun, or a word or group of words acting like a noun, can be the subject or object of a verb. So, a phrase which is the subject or object of a verb is a noun phrase. Remember that a noun phrase, like a noun, can be the object of a preposition also.

- (l) Eating junk food is not good for health.

Eating junk food does not contain a subject and a verb.

So, it is a *phrase*. It is the subject of the verb *is*. It is, therefore, a *noun phrase*.

(Q: What is not good for health? Ans: *Eating junk food*)

- (m) Anand enjoys playing chess.

(Q: What does Anand enjoy? Ans: *playing chess*)

Here, *playing chess* is the object of the verb *enjoys*. As it does not contain a subject and a predicate, it is a phrase acting like a noun, or a noun phrase.

- (n) Mother made a cake with lots of chocolate and cream.

In this sentence, *lots of chocolate and cream* is a noun phrase and the object of the preposition *with*.



C Pick out the **noun phrases** from the following sentences:

1. Getting up early in the morning is a good habit.
2. I could not eat the stale, half-burnt pieces of toast.
3. I cannot remember the names of people, but I can remember their faces.
4. All the children were given beautifully wrapped gifts.
5. Vijay lay down on the soft and large bed and went to sleep.
6. Some people love travelling to far and distant places.
7. The meeting of the committee will be held in the library.
8. Does anybody like working on a holiday?
9. 'Do not forget to take your lunch box,' Ma warned Rakesh.
10. Asking questions is a scientist's favourite occupation.
11. The teachings of Socrates have been recorded by his pupil Plato.
12. The farmer ploughed his little plot of land and hoped for a good harvest.
13. The plays of Shakespeare have been admired by people of different countries and ages.
14. The battalion of soldiers was going home after a long time.
15. Do you like listening to ghost stories on a dark and windy night?

